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Mohammad: Hope can transform societies

DUBAI

Gulf News Report

His Highness Shaikh Mohammad Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, yesterday announced the launch of a new edition of the Arab Hope Makers initiative, a pan-Arab project aimed at honouring and celebrating individuals who are making a tangible difference in their communities across the Arab world.

In a post shared on his X account, Shaikh Mohammad stressed that hope can transform societies. "Human beings live with hope, and societies are built on the power of hope. The greatest challenges become easier when faced with genuine hope."

"Today, we are launching a new edition of Arab Hope Makers. We will search for them in every community, in every village and neighbourhood to celebrate and empower them."

"Those who believe in the goodness within themselves can nominate themselves or others at <http://arabhopemakers.com>."

Five finalists will take home Dh1 million to support their humanitarian endeavours.

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Arab states, US, EU call for peaceful transition in Syria

UN ENVOY URGES LIFTING OF SANCTIONS TO SUPPORT REBUILDING EFFORTS

DUBAI

BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

Top Arab diplomats, the US and the European Union have called for a peaceful transition in Syria, as the Americans engage directly with the rebel group that ousted Bashar Al Assad.

In a meeting held in Aqaba, Jordan, foreign ministers from the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Bahrain, Qatar, Jordan, Iraq, Egypt, and Lebanon expressed their commitment to supporting a transition process that ensures representation for all political and social groups in Syria.

The ministers emphasised the need for a transitional government agreed upon by Syrians, leading to the establishment of a political system reflecting the aspirations of all citizens, with the support of the UN and the Arab League.

Maintaining Syria's state institutions was a key priority to prevent the country from descending into chaos, they said.

The ministers' call echoes the G7 nations, who on Thursday expressed their readiness to support Syria's transition towards an inclusive, non-sectarian government following the swift offensive by anti-Al Assad forces.

A joint statement issued late Saturday by the US, EU, Turkey



AFP

■ Syrian students rally near the campus of the Damascus University yesterday. Schools and universities reopened yesterday for the first time since the fall of Al Assad a week ago.

and Arab states called for an end to hostilities and suggested that Syria could reintegrate into the international community if it adheres to principles agreed upon in Aqaba.

Historical grievances

Joshua Landis, a leading expert on Syria, has said that inclusive governance would require overcoming historical grievances

among Syria's diverse communities, including Kurds, Arabs, Sunnis, Alawites and Christians.

US Secretary of State Antony Blinken, who also attended the Aqaba meeting, confirmed direct US engagement with HTS rebels. He hinted at potential sanctions relief, stating that the US would consider adjustments to its measures as the post-Al Assad transition progresses in

line with American objectives. Visiting Damascus, UN Special Envoy for Syria Geir Pedersen, yesterday urged the lifting of sanctions to support Syria's rebuilding efforts. Pedersen, who will meet officials from the newly-established interim government called for justice and accountability in the country, discouraging acts of revenge.

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NATION

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UAE banks help residents get more shopping discounts

Retailers predict 20 per cent growth in sales compared to last year

DUBAI

BY MANOJ NAIR
Business Editor

Retailers in the UAE are offering significant discounts this December, with heavy support from banks through partnerships, like providing up to 10 per cent additional discounts on top of Black Friday deals.

Retailers, including Eros, are predicting a 20 per cent growth in sales compared to last year, driven by such strong offers. In particular, partnerships with platforms like noon and Emir-

ates NBD, along with special credit cards offering discounts across various categories, are encouraging spending. Shoppers are responding well, with many visiting malls early in the day to take advantage of promotions.

Tourist traffic in Dubai also boosts retail sales. The strong dollar, fueled by recent political events, has led to lower prices for imported goods, further benefiting consumers. Additionally, re-

tailers, particularly in tech and fashion, have been aggressive with their discounts. The Dubai Shopping Festival (DSF), running from December 6 to January 12, adds to the excitement, with gold raffles offering prizes worth millions.

The UAE's status as the City of Gold is reinforced, with major promotions in jewellery stores. Online sales are also booming, especially through in-app purchases, which saw a 74 per cent increase during Black Friday. This reflects the growing trend of mobile commerce in the region, with brands using strategies to engage customers and drive sales. Overall, December is shaping up to be a prosperous month for UAE retailers.

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74%

increase in online purchases during Black Friday sales

SPORT

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